

NEGATIVE-REVIEW PLAYBOOK

Negative-review triage checklist

The 8-step playbook for 1-star and 2-star reviews — pre-checks, lane decision, draft from template, safety check, post, log, and the Google policy flag.

PRODUCT

Med Spa Review + Local SEO Toolkit

\$49 one-time · 7-day refund · Google Drive folder of editable assets.

SUPPORT

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SpaReply is informational. The toolkit is HIPAA-aware editorial guidance — not legal, medical, or compliance advice. Final compliance decisions belong with your provider, privacy officer, and counsel.

Negative-review triage checklist

SpaReply Med Spa Review + Local SEO Toolkit · editable copy Clinic: [Practice Name] · Owner of this checklist: [Practice Manager Name]

Negative reviews are the highest-stakes reply your team will write. Run this checklist before anything goes live. The goal isn't to win the argument — it's to make the next reader feel like the clinic is a calm, careful place.

Pre-checks · do these before you write a word

- ☐ Confirm the review is on Google Business Profile (not Yelp / Reddit / RealSelf — those have separate playbooks).
 - ☐ Confirm it's a real guest, not a competitor or bot. If it looks fake, see step 8 below.
 - ☐ Note the star rating. 1& 2& always go to the practice manager before posting. 3& may go to the front-desk lead with practice-manager review.
 - ☐ Pull a tracker row open before drafting — date, guest first name, star rating, category, provider.
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The 8-step triage

1. Acknowledge within 24 business hours

A 1- or 2-star review left unanswered for a week reads worse than the review itself. Front-desk lead pings the practice manager the same day; the public reply does not need to be perfect, only careful.

- ☐ Practice manager pinged within 4 business hours of the review going live.
- ☐ Public reply drafted within 24 business hours.

2. Identify the guest internally — quietly

Search your booking system for the name in the review. Note their last visit, provider, and any prior issues in the internal tracker. Do not reference any of that in the public reply.

- ☐ Found in booking system (or marked "no record found").

- ☐ Last visit date and provider noted in the tracker only.
- ☐ Prior issues, if any, noted in the tracker only.

3. Decide the lane: clinical, operational, billing, or hostile

Each lane has a different default reply.

- ☐ **Clinical** !' routes to a licensed provider. Public reply offers a private channel; the actual conversation happens with the provider.
- ☐ **Operational** (wait time, room turnover, communication) !' routes to the practice manager. Public reply acknowledges, names no excuse, points to private follow-up.
- ☐ **Billing or scheduling** !' routes to the office manager. Public reply moves the conversation offline.
- ☐ **Hostile / bot-like** !' calm public reply, no debate. Flag through GBP if it violates Google's policy.

4. Draft the public reply from the closest template

Use the negative-review templates in the template-bank doc. Replace placeholders. Cut anything that names a treatment, outcome, or scope. Keep the public reply under 90 words.

- ☐ Started from a template, not a blank page.
- ☐ Bracketed placeholders replaced.
- ☐ Under 90 words.
- ☐ No clinical specifics, no liability admission, no public refund offer.

5. Run the 7-question pre-post safety check

- ☐ Did the guest write the detail publicly first?
- ☐ Is the reply free of treatment specifics the guest did not name?
- ☐ Free of outcome promises (skin cleared, pain gone, results lasted)?
- ☐ Was anything sensitive moved to a private channel?
- ☐ Has a second person at [Practice Name] read this?
- ☐ Does the tone match a calm, well-run clinic?
- ☐ Are we within 24 business hours of the review going live?

If any answer is "no," send the draft back to the practice manager.

6. Post the public reply, then send the private follow-up

Public reply goes live first. Then the practice manager sends a private email or call referencing the offer in the public reply. The private follow-up is where the actual resolution happens.

- ☐ Public reply posted.
- ☐ Private follow-up sent within 1 business day of posting.
- ☐ Channel of follow-up noted (email / phone / both).

7. Log it in the tracker — every time

Date · guest first name · star rating · category · provider · public reply link · private follow-up status · resolution. The log is what turns review noise into operational signal at the monthly roll-up.

- ☐ Row added to the tracker.
- ☐ Public reply link captured.
- ☐ Resolution updated when the private conversation closes.

8. Escalate flags or report fakes through Google

If a review violates Google's policy (off-topic, fake, conflict of interest, hate speech), flag it through your GBP dashboard. Don't argue with it publicly while you wait — post the calm default reply, then flag.

- ☐ Flagged through GBP if applicable.
- ☐ Screenshot kept in the tracker for evidence.
- ☐ Re-flag if not actioned within 14 days.

The "do not post" list

If any of these are true, stop and bring it to the practice manager before any public reply goes live.

- The guest names a clinical adverse event.
- The guest names a regulator (state board, FDA, OSHA, OCR).
- The guest threatens legal action or names an attorney.
- The reply you drafted confirms a treatment the guest did not name.
- The reply you drafted apologizes for a specific outcome.
- The reply offers a refund, comp, or credit publicly.
- You can't answer "yes" to all seven safety-check questions.

Owner sign-off

I confirm the public reply for the review dated [Review Date] meets the SpaReply HIPAA-aware editorial guardrails and the [Practice Name] reply policy.

- Practice manager: _____ Date: _____
- Second reader: _____ Date: _____

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